

Facing your Fears : Exposure Therapy

We're often told to "face our fears", but it turns out that that might not just be a motivational quote, but an actual form of psychological therapy. This is what is commonly called "Exposure therapy" – a form of therapy that involves literally "exposing" yourself to the things you fear most, or are uncomfortable with. Exposure therapy has been shown to be extremely effective in cases of common mental issues like depression, anxiety, post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) and even various phobias.

Exposure therapy falls under the broad umbrella of Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT). CBT is about your cognition – the way you process and acquire knowledge through your thoughts, experiences and senses. CBT focusses on the links between one's thoughts, behaviours and feelings and how they are interconnected and influence each other. Changing your thoughts or your behaviour and how you interact with a subject can help change your feelings on that subject. Therapists use CBT to replace negative thought patterns like overgeneralizing and catastrophizing with more positive associations. This is done by challenging certain trains of thoughts and the way that people react to certain habits or behaviours. By successfully altering thoughts and behaviours about certain situations, we can go on to change the way we feel about those situations.

Exposure therapy, as mentioned before, focusses on confronting your fears. We tend to avoid situations that scare us or make us uncomfortable. The exposure is done in different ways – one can be exposed to the situation in question directly, or asked to imagine it vividly. Technological advancement like the advent of virtual reality have also worked their way into the therapy. The exposure can be done over time – sometimes it's done in a hierarchical manner, in increasing order of the difficulty of the task; or sometimes even "flooded" with the situation.

Exposure changes the way you process an uncomfortable situation, and modifies your behaviour in relation to an uncomfortable situation. The links between behaviours, thoughts and feelings are then successful in modifying your reaction to that stimuli. Exposure therapy is not just about getting accustomed to the fear. It's about retraining your brain. It is about redefining your relationship with the fear. Often, we ignore negative trains of thought thinking that will make them go away but they lurk in corners of our mind. By confronting your fear, by confronting that uncomfortable situation, you are able to rewrite your connection to the fear.

Purely biologically, exposure therapy works by retraining your amygdala. The amygdala is that part of your brain that is responsible for fight/flight – the purely unconscious reflexive response to danger. Fight/flight responses are unbiased – whether the danger be a tiger ready to pounce on you, or a public speaking situation, your brain responds in the same way. Fight/Flight has nothing to do with your intellect or processing power, it is quite literally a "gut feeling". Fight/flight evolves with association – your amygdala remembers the negative experiences you've had, and remembers to avoid them. By exposing yourself to the things you aren't comfortable with on a low risk basis, you are able to redefine your association with the experience – you're able to overcome your fear. It is extremely difficult at times, especially at the beginning, but exposure therapy has been seen to improve the conditions of hundreds of patients all over.

Therapy of any kind is associated with some level of stigma. "Getting help", especially as applied to mental disorders, is often seen as a sign of weakness. Popular perception of therapy and mental illness is the armchair psychologist coupled with the patient pouring their heart out about their daddy issues. But, therapy has come a long way since Freudian times. Mental health awareness has become more and more of a priority now, and certain topics like depression and anxiety have

become more seriously considered today. The road to complete de-stigmatization is a long one but we have started our journey on it. Methods like exposure therapy are interactive and personalised to an individual's experiences.

It is important to remember that no matter how bad or scary something seems, it is often best to just go through with it. Exposure therapy just reaffirms and scientifically confirms something we've intuitively known all along - that the only way to make it in life is to take some risks. With the right support system and the appropriate environment, one can successfully navigate themselves through their fears and anxieties. As we celebrate World Mental Health day this month, let us help make this environment more conducive and inclusive for those who face such struggles – let us help them face their fears in a safe manner.